

August 30, 2026

To Portland Voters and Civic Leaders,

We, the three undersigned, are university professors of political science who have spent our careers researching participatory budgeting. We co-authored *Participatory Budgeting in Global Perspective* (2021), a book that summarizes research across six continents on how different participatory budgeting design features produced significantly different programmatic outcomes around the world.

We reviewed the [proposed charter amendment \(Measure 26-267\)](#) Portland voters will consider on their November 3 ballot and want to provide our assessment, from a global perspective, on the proposed policy based on our research and our knowledge of conditions in Portland. We believe Portland would be particularly well positioned to implement successful, high impact participatory budgeting (PB) under Measure 26-267 for several reasons.

1. **Measure 26-267 establishes charter-mandated PB but provides for flexible implementation.** PB is a reform that aims to shift the distribution of budgeting power to allow residents to directly make some budget decisions. Research on PB supports establishing PB in city charters while also providing flexibility for adaptation and improvement over time. Measure 26-267 is well crafted to apply a clear mandate for PB, while setting Portland up for success in providing flexibility for public officials to adapt, refine, and improve the program over time.
2. **Measure 26-267 allocates sufficient funds to make participatory budgeting meaningful and impactful.** Measure 26-267 will establish a citywide PB program that allocates at least \$1 million per 100,000 residents, a recognized best practice. Allocating sufficient funds through PB is one key way that cities can achieve more participation and better outcomes, including specific goals for PB.
3. **Measure 26-267 provides a clear mandate for PB program evaluation and improvement over time.** Research demonstrates that setting clear goals for PB programs as well as regularly evaluating implementation promotes better outcomes over time. Measure 26-267 provides a clear mandate to "*evaluate the PB program and recommend changes in the process*" specifically "*to improve desired impacts and outcomes and to increase participation of all residents in all phases of the process.*"

It is our assessment that Measure 26-267 has clearly been informed by the best available research on the global determinants of high impact PB programs. This is important because many municipalities in the US allocate relatively low amounts of public money, lack robust systems of evaluation, and/or do not have legal provisions (charter mandates) to ensure long-term growth and success.

Finally, Portland's relatively strong civil society and social movements provide key pre-conditions for high-impact PB under Measure 26-267. Since PB is a reform that residents and governments implement together, the strength of local civil society and social movements matters significantly in delivering higher impact outcomes. For this reason, Portland is well-positioned to achieve the robust participation witnessed in places like in France, Spain, Brazil, and South Korea.

Many municipalities around the globe have succeeded to a great degree in strengthening democratic institutions, increasing public trust, fostering more responsive government, and/or expanding inclusive governance through PB. Our research suggests Portland voters have a unique opportunity to do the same for their city by adopting Measure 26-267 on November 3.

Sincerely,



Dr. Brian Wampler, Distinguished Professor. Boise State University



Dr. Michael Touchton, Independent Scholar & Researcher, PhD Political Science



Dr. Stephanie McNulty, Professor, Franklin and Marshall College

Cited:

Wampler, B., McNulty, S., & Touchton, M. (2021). *Participatory Budgeting in Global Perspective*. Oxford University Press.